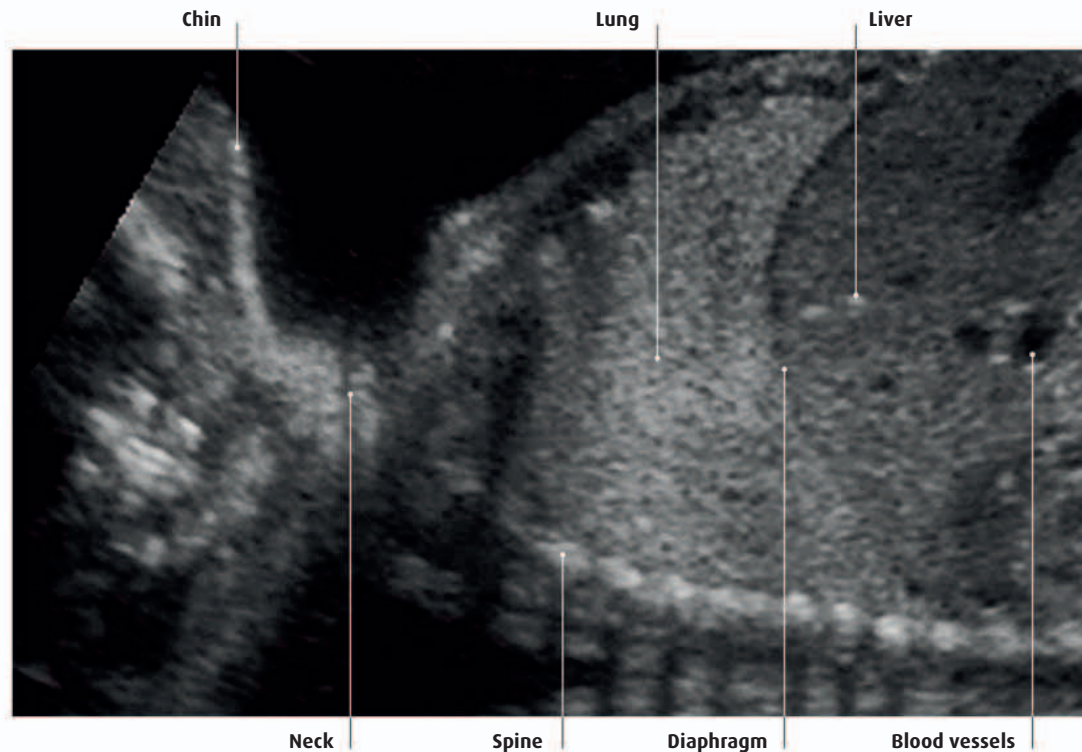


Q What is the anatomy scan?

Between 18 and 22 weeks pregnant you'll be offered a midterm (or midpregnancy) ultrasound. It is known as the anatomy scan. This is the first point in your pregnancy when a sonographer can make a detailed assessment of your unborn baby's health. A series of measurements are taken and physical features are checked to ensure there are no defects.

Seeing your baby

This is an exciting, but also potentially anxious time for prospective parents—the image you see of your baby on the ultrasound screen will, possibly for the first time, really look like a baby now. Even without specialized training, you'll be able to make out his eyes, ears, nose, fingers, vertebrae, and even perhaps some fingers and toes. At the same time, you will hear whether your baby is developing healthily. If you're worried, remember that most anatomy scans turn out to be happy, reassuring occasions. Only very rarely are parents faced with news that dramatically affects the care a baby might need after birth, or a difficult decision about whether or not to continue with the pregnancy at all.



Did you know...

The heartbeat of a healthy adult at rest is around around 60–90 beats per minute (bpm). The following are the beats per minute (plus or minus 20 beats) that a sonographer or your doctor would expect for your baby's heart at various stages in your pregnancy:

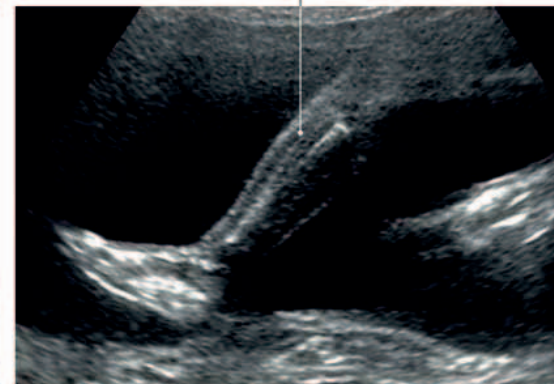
- » 155 bpm at 20 weeks pregnant
- » 144 bpm at 30 weeks pregnant
- » 140 bpm at full term (around 40 weeks) pregnant

Heart ventricles and atriums



Your baby's heart The four chambers of the heart are checked to see if they are roughly the same size as each other, making sure the valves between them are working. If any problem is detected, you will be referred to a heart specialist for more detailed checks on your baby.

Leg



Your baby's leg A measurement is taken of your baby's femur (thigh bone), which gives a good indication as to how he is growing. Your baby's feet, toes, hands, and fingers will also be examined, checking that the digits are present—although they won't be counted now.